

Statement of intent

Baha Khammari · PhD position, auction-based support schemes for renewable energy
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My energy training is at Cologne, where the Institute of Energy Economics teaches the specialisation. I took *Energy Markets and Regulation* with Jun.-Prof. Dr. Oliver Ruhnau, whose chair is in energy market design, and finished it with 1.3 on a scale where 1.0 is the maximum.

My final seminar paper is a research design on carbon leakage from the EU Emissions Trading System, written as groundwork for a master's thesis I decided in the end not to write. It asks whether a higher effective carbon cost raised EU imports of emission-intensive goods from Morocco, Algeria, Egypt and Tunisia between 2005 and 2021, against the aggregate null in Naegele and Zaklan (2019), and identifies from a triple difference. One feature of its treatment definition is why I am writing to this project rather than to a general applied-micro post. I define the effective carbon cost as the allowance price attenuated by the sector-year free-allocation share, so a fully allocated sector faces an effective cost of zero whatever the headline price does. The obvious objection is that tradable allowances carry the permit price as marginal opportunity cost, so a lump-sum grant should leave the output margin untouched. EU allocation is not lump-sum in that sense: activity thresholds, closure provisions and partial-cessation rules tie allowances to continued production. The headline price of an instrument and the incentive it creates are different objects, and the gap between them is a property of the rules.

An auction poses the same problem. An award price is not the support a project effectively receives once pre-qualification requirements, penalties, completion bonds and local content conditions are priced into the bid. Of the four directions in the call, I would take up pre-qualification with completion bonds, and local content requirements.

The empirical obstacle is that member states adopted auctions at different dates and revised the rules at different dates again, which is staggered adoption of a treatment whose intensity varies across adopters. My master's thesis, graded 1.0, was built for that setting. Using the estimator of Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021) on a panel of roughly five million linked employer-employee records I constructed, the doubly-robust estimate is a wage effect of +3.04 per cent, against -0.65 per cent from two-way fixed effects on the same data. The sign reverses for the reason Goodman-Bacon (2021) identifies, and I know it does because I ran the decomposition.

The call asks for graduate training in microeconomic theory, industrial organization and game theory. My master's microeconomics grade is 3.0 and the transcripts show it. At bachelor level microeconomics is 1.0, and advanced microeconomics, on strategic thinking and competition with Prof. Dr. Axel Ockenfels, is 1.3, so game theory and competition are not new to me. What I would genuinely be building is graduate industrial organization, and that is coursework and reading.

I complete my M.Sc. this month and am available from October 2026, which fits the autumn start. I speak French at B1, which matters for living and working in Louvain-la-Neuve, alongside German and Tunisian Arabic natively and English at IELTS Academic 8.0. I hold EU citizenship. My referees are Prof. Dr. Pia Pinger, who chaired my master's thesis, and Jun.-Prof. Dr. Oliver Ruhnau, with contact details on the CV. The thesis and the seminar paper are available on request.

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